



**V**enerated since time immortal for its cosmetic and medicinal properties, and exalted in China as the 'king of flowers', the Peony is revered by gardeners and flower aficionados the world over. French growers in Provence are wild for the matchless blossom, cultivated in a massive, unequalled range of variations at Maison Rivière for the past 150 years.

The story of the Maison and the thriving abundance of Peony flowers in France goes back to 1848, when Fleury Jean-Baptiste Gabriel Ruitton first grew herbaceous Peonies, a tradition that was passed down to his son-in law, Benoit Rivière. In 1908, the garden catalogue hit more than 400 varieties, with each generation of the Rivières bringing back rare strains from around the world. Jean-Luc Rivière, sixth in line, now sustains his heritage, establishing the Crest garden site at the foothills of the Rhône, Dauphiné, Vercors and Provence regions, dedicated exclusively to growing over 750 different types of the Peony.

## NEW HORIZONS

Recently, at the L'Occitane laboratory in Manosque, the Rivière family's Peony collection became the centre of research into *Paeonia lactiflora*—a species of peony historically used for its therapeutic properties. Using enzymatic hydrolysis, which breaks up the extract into micro-fragments that are easily absorbed by the skin, scientists created a new peony extract that harnesses

# COMING UP PEONIES

The inimitable fleur grown on the crests of Provence: what makes it so sublime, how it's harvested and the amazing effect it has on skin

the flower's skin-perfecting properties.

This newly discovered extract has now been bottled and infused by L'Occitane into their new Perfecting Peony Complex. Coupled with hyaluronic acid, horse chestnut extract and mineral pigments, the Complex transforms the skin's surface texture, plumping it with radiance and more support and bounce. The product's intelligent, natural texture, derived from beeswax and jojoba wax, adapts to any skin type and climate, for a light, non-oily finish. Add to all that soft-focus mineralised powders that instantly blur imperfections for the appearance of smooth, flawless skin with a rosy glow. We love the Perfecting Cream, RM172 and Skin Perfector Serum, RM198—it's adaptive, ultra-moisturising and imperfection-kicking goodness from one mighty bud. **mc**

Not to be missed is the Pivoine Flora (Peony Flower) body range, with an EDT, Shower Gel, Beauty Milk, Bath Oil, Petal Soap and Hand Cream, all infused with the floral, fresh, zesty smell of Peony. We also love these Tinted Lip Balms, RM83, to evoke that rosy glow on your lips as well.



## AROUND THE WORLD

In **Japan**, the peony is called 'botan', and is used as traditional medicine. Because of its lush petals and delicate scent, it is also cultivated as a garden plant.

In **China**, the peony is known as 'fu gui hua' or 'flower of riches and honour'. Back in the day, fallen peony petals were parboiled and sweetened as a tea-time delicacy,

and peony water was used for drinking. In 1903, the Qing Dynasty declared the peony as the national flower.

In **North America**, peonies are grown for their ornamental value and is also the official state flower of Indiana.

In **Europe**, the peony is referred to as 'the rose without thorns'. The fragrance of the flower is also captured in many French perfumes.